

Rehabilitation During Conflicts

Why rehabilitation is recognised as an essential health service in conflicts — and what it takes to deliver it.

Did you know?

Rehabilitation is recognised in global emergency response standards as an essential health service in conflicts — yet access to rehabilitation remains limited in many conflict settings.

WHAT IS REHABILITATION IN CONFLICTS?

Rehabilitation during conflict focuses on restoring functioning, preventing complications, and supporting reintegration into community life. Early rehabilitation reduces complications, shortens hospital stays, and improves long-term recovery.

Rehabilitation in conflicts is essential for:

- Persons with new conflict-related injuries such as fractures, amputations, burns, spinal cord injuries, traumatic brain injuries, and peripheral nerve injuries.
- Persons with existing disabilities, functional limitations, or health conditions whose usual services are disrupted during conflict.
- Supporting psychological and social recovery from the trauma and displacement associated with conflict.

CURRENT SITUATION

1B+

people live in fragile, conflict-affected, or violent settings (World Bank)

1 in 6

children globally live in areas affected by conflict (UNICEF)

Highest since WW2

the world is experiencing the highest number of conflicts since World War 2 (UNICEF)

Many conflicts are increasing in duration and complexity worldwide. International Humanitarian Law protects the wounded and sick, persons with disabilities, health personnel, and health facilities — including rehabilitation workers and facilities. In practice, these protections are too often violated. Global standards — including the WHO EMT Minimum Technical Standards, the ICRC guidelines, and the Sphere Handbook — recognise rehabilitation as part of the essential health response. Yet in most conflict settings, rehabilitation services remain under-resourced and under-prioritised.

ROLE OF REHABILITATION

Rehabilitation plays a critical role across the continuum of care — from the onset of injury through acute and rehabilitation care, discharge to home, and community reintegration.

- **Optimising recovery:** promoting independence, functioning, and reintegration into family and community life.
- **Injury management:** functional training and provision of assistive devices such as wheelchairs, prostheses, and orthoses.
- **Preventing secondary complications:** reducing morbidity and mortality associated with immobility and inadequate care.
- **Supporting patient flow:** through health facilities in mass casualty incidents, reducing pressure on surgical and medical teams.
- **Shortening hospital stays:** enabling earlier and safer discharge to community settings.
- **Supporting psychological recovery:** alongside mental health care, helping survivors manage trauma and rebuild their lives.

ACTIONS NEEDED

- Protect health facilities and staff, ensuring unimpeded access to care in accordance with International Humanitarian Law.
- Include rehabilitation professionals at all levels of hospital, outpatient, and community care as part of standard conflict response — including in Emergency Medical Teams — as required by EMT and Sphere standards.
- Respect and invest in local rehabilitation capacity, ensuring effective and sustainable support and development of rehabilitation systems and services within affected communities.
- Fund and deliver essential rehabilitation supplies, including assistive products, as part of emergency health kits.
- Ensure rehabilitation data are collected throughout the conflict response to monitor need, guide resource allocation, and support accountability.

The imperative to integrate rehabilitation in conflict health responses is already recognised in global standards. The remaining challenge lies in implementation and investment — ensuring rehabilitation is a consistent component of conflict response so people can survive, recover, and live with dignity.

About the World Rehabilitation Alliance

The World Rehabilitation Alliance is a WHO-hosted global network of more than 100 member organisations advancing rehabilitation in health systems and the recognition of functioning as a dimension of population health. Anchored in the Rehabilitation 2030 Initiative and WHA Resolution 76.6 (2023), the Alliance convenes partners across health, policy, and the wider development community.